One of these Roman citizens could well have been the Christian missionary Judas Thomas, because, according to South Indian Syrian Christian tradition, Muciri was where the founding father of their church stepped ashore in 52 CE, going on to found seven churches along the coast and convert eleven prominent Brahmin families before being martyred, with his remains buried at Mylapore, today a Brahmin stronghold in modern Chennai. Jewish refugees are also said to have entered India by way of Muciri, in the wake of the Roman destruction of Solomon's temple in Jerusalem and the dispersal of the Jews in 70 CE.

A poem in the early Tamil bardic anthology *Akananuru* describes Muciri as 'the city where the beautiful vessels, the masterpieces of the *Yavanas* [Westerners], stir white foam on the Culli [Periyar], river of Chera [Kerala], arriving with gold and departing with pepper, when that Muciri, brimming with prosperity, was besieged by the din of war'.[3] Another poem, from the *Purananuru*, speaks of Muciri as 'the city that bestows wealth on its visitors', and as a treasure-house where sacks of pepper were piled up alongside heaps of gold.

The Romans thought equally highly of Muciri, to the extent of describing it as 'primum emporium Indiae' and 'the most important trade-centre in India'. However, Pliny the Elder in his *Natural History* notes that it was inconveniently sited up-river and much troubled by pirates – presumably those same pirates the *Tabula Peutingeriana* warns about in capital letters. 'If the wind, called *Hippalus* [the South-west Monsoon], happens to be blowing,' Pliny writes,

> it is possible to arrive in forty days at the nearest market in India, *Muziris* by name. This, however, is not a very desirable place for disembarkation, on account of the pirates which frequent its vicinity … Besides, the roadstead for shipping is a considerable distance from